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Inter-agency *Deliberation*

Select agencies to activate. Enter a policy proposal. An orchestrator synthesises fault lines, consensus, and blind spots.

SYNTHESIS MODE

Standard Fault lines, consensus, blind spots

Synergies Cohesion, collaboration, joint action

ACTIVE AGENCIES

MTI Ministry of Trade and Industry

MSF Ministry of Social and Family Development

MHA Ministry of Home Affairs

MCCY Ministry of Community, Culture, and Youth

MOE Ministry of Education

MINDEF Ministry of Defence

mforeign Ministry of Foreign Affairs

MOM Ministry of Manpower

MSE Ministry of Sustainability and the Environment

MND Ministry of National Development

MOT Ministry of Transport

SNDG Smart Nation and Digital Government Group

MINLAW Ministry of Law

MOH Ministry of Health

COMMS Communications

PSD Public Service Division

MOF Ministry of Finance

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POLICY PROPOSAL

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Proposal: Free Off-Peak Public Transport for Seniors
Draft for inter-agency consultation — for discussion only
1. Background

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MSF *Ministry of Social and Family Development*

MINISTRY OF SOCIAL AND FAMILY DEVELOPMENT Inter-Agency Consultation Response Free Off-Peak Public Transport for Seniors — Draft Proposal For Discussion

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Overall Position

MSF supports the intent. Social isolation among seniors is a real and underdiagnosed welfare risk. Transport cost is a genuine barrier for lower-income seniors, and we know from our social service officers and family service centre caseworkers that it shows up in how often people access services, not just social visits. We have concerns, however, about design choices that will determine whether this proposal actually reaches the people it is meant to help.

What the Proposal Gets Right

The automatic eligibility mechanism is the single most important design decision in this document, and it is the right one. Means-tested schemes that require application consistently fail the most isolated and most vulnerable. Our experience with ComCare and Silver Support confirms this: the people who most need help are often the last to apply. No new application removes that barrier. We support this without qualification.

The off-peak targeting also aligns with the actual pattern of socially isolated seniors. They are not commuting. They are visiting, attending activities, or accessing services — trips that can flex around peak hours. The timing works for the stated objective.

Concerns

1. Universality is the wrong frame for this problem.

The proposal presents free travel for all seniors aged 65 and above as its default. That includes seniors who are asset-rich, have occupational pensions, or are still working. At $95 million annually — rising — this is a substantial commitment of public funds. We are not opposed to universality on principle, but we need the proposal to justify it.

The stated objectives are reducing isolation and easing cost-of-living pressure on low or fixed incomes. Both are targeted problems. A universal benefit addresses neither with precision. It delivers a windfall to seniors who do not need it, while doing nothing additional for the seniors who do.

The counterargument — that universality removes stigma and ensures uptake — is legitimate but overstated here. The Senior Citizen Concession Card is already universal. There is no additional stigma in extending a benefit that flows automatically through a card everyone already holds, even if the benefit is means-conditioned on the back end.

MSF's strong preference is a tiered structure: free travel for seniors on Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, and Merdeka Generation status; retained concessionary fares for all others. This concentrates benefit where need is greatest, at significantly lower fiscal cost, and does not require a

new application.

2. The age threshold misaligns with the problem.

The proposal shifts eligibility from 60 to 65. The stated rationale appears to be fiscal. But the seniors most at risk of isolation are often older, frailer, and more likely to be on fixed incomes. That is not an argument against 65. It is an argument for being explicit about why 65 was chosen and whether that choice was driven by evidence about need or by budget arithmetic.

More concretely: seniors currently on the Concession Card between 60 and 64 will see no benefit from this scheme and may perceive it as exclusion. We need to understand whether any group in this cohort is at elevated isolation risk and whether the proposal inadvertently creates a gap.

3. The fiscal commitment is open-ended and the review mechanism is weak.

The proposal flags $95 million rising to $140 million by 2032. The commitment is permanent by design, with a review only after three years. That review is described as within the transport budget envelope — which means it is MOT and LTA's problem to manage, with no clear mechanism for MSF or MOF to weigh in on whether the welfare outcomes justify continued expenditure.

MSF does not oppose long-term commitments when they are warranted. But a permanent, universally applied spending commitment of this scale should have clearer evaluation criteria and a genuine decision point — not a review that amounts to a rubber stamp. We recommend a time-limited scheme of five years with a statutory evaluation requirement, including welfare outcome data, not just ridership data.

4. Ridership data is not welfare outcome data.

This is a prospective concern. LTA will naturally measure success by ridership uplift and network utilisation. Those are not the same as reduced social isolation or improved senior wellbeing. MSF will need to be involved in the evaluation framework from the outset. We should be tracking: activity participation rates, self-reported loneliness indicators, mental health service utilisation, and access to community services. These are harder to measure. They are also what the proposal is actually trying to achieve.

If we evaluate this scheme only on transport metrics, we will declare success while missing failure.

5. The proposal does not address non-transport barriers to mobility.

Transport cost is one reason isolated seniors leave home less. It is not the only reason, and for some seniors it is not the primary reason. Physical frailty, fear of falling, cognitive decline, lack of accompaniment, and unfamiliarity with transit routes all constrain mobility. For seniors with these barriers, free fares accomplish nothing.

MSF is not arguing this proposal should solve all problems. We are flagging that the link between free travel and reduced isolation is assumed, not established. For a significant subset of the most isolated seniors — the very old, those with early dementia, those without family support — the constraint is not cost. A scheme designed around cost relief will not reach them.

This does not mean the proposal is wrong. It means it needs to sit within a broader active ageing and social isolation strategy, not stand alone as if it solves the problem.

6. Complementary capacity needs to be in place.

If free travel succeeds in increasing seniors' access to community activities, family service centres, and social service touchpoints — good. But those services need to be able to absorb increased demand. MSF's sector is not operating with spare capacity. If this proposal works as intended, it will generate more footfall at senior activity centres, family service centres, and community mental health touchpoints. Funding for those services needs to move in tandem, not lag behind.

This is a coordination issue between MSF, MOH, and PA. It needs to be resolved before July 2027, not after.

Specific Answers to the Open Questions

Should free travel be universal or limited to lower-income seniors?

Limited. Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, and Merdeka Generation as the threshold. Automatic, no new application. This is fiscally responsible and welfare-targeted without adding administrative burden.

Will free travel shift trips into peak-hour edges?

Probably marginally, for working seniors or those accompanying grandchildren on school runs. This is an LTA operational question, not primarily MSF's. We note that the seniors most at risk of isolation are unlikely to have strong peak-hour incentives. We do not regard this as a major welfare concern.

Is an open-ended commitment prudent?

No. Five-year time-limited scheme with a statutory evaluation, welfare outcome metrics defined in advance, and a genuine decision point before renewal. If it works, renewal is justified and easy to defend. If it does not, we need the mechanism to change course.

Summary

Support the proposal in modified form. Universal free travel is a blunt instrument for a targeted problem. Limit free travel to seniors in established lower-income schemes, keep automatic eligibility, set a five-year term with real evaluation criteria, and ensure MSF is in the room when outcomes are measured — not just LTA. The proposal also needs to be honest that transport cost is one barrier among several, and that the most isolated seniors may not be reached by this measure at all. Plan accordingly.

Submitted for inter-agency consultation. MSF is available to discuss at working level.

MOT *Ministry of Transport*

MINISTRY OF TRANSPORT

Inter-Agency Consultation Response

Free Off-Peak Public Transport for Seniors — Draft Proposal

For Discussion

Overall Position

MOT supports the policy objective. We have significant concerns about fiscal design, operational assumptions, and evaluation framing. Several of these overlap with MSF's submission. Where they do, we will not repeat the argument — we will note agreement and add what MOT can add. Where we disagree, we will say so plainly.

What the Proposal Gets Right

The off-peak targeting is operationally sound. The network has genuine spare capacity in those windows. Shifting senior trips into that space is a legitimate use of underutilised infrastructure and does not require capital expenditure to deliver. This is good transport policy independent of the welfare rationale.

The automatic eligibility mechanism is correct. MOT agrees with MSF on this without reservation. Any scheme that requires a new application will underserve its intended population. The Senior Citizen Concession Card is already the right delivery channel.

The modal scope — MRT, LRT, bus — is appropriate. There is no case for extending this to taxis or ride-hail. That would be a different policy with a different cost structure and a different set of winners.

Concerns

1. The revenue loss figure needs to be stress-tested.

The proposal states $95 million annually, rising to $140 million by 2032. MOT does not dispute the direction. We dispute the precision.

That estimate depends on assumptions about current senior ridership patterns, how many additional trips free travel generates, and the age distribution of the eligible cohort. None of these are simple. Induced demand from a zero-price signal is notoriously difficult to model accurately. If uptake exceeds projections — which zero-price schemes frequently produce — the cost rises faster than forecast, and the proposal's assurance that costs sit within the existing transport budget envelope collapses.

LTA should publish the demand elasticity assumptions underlying the $95 million figure before this goes further. The inter-agency group should scrutinise them. A scheme that commits to permanent compensation to operators from the Consolidated Fund on the basis of an unvalidated demand model is a fiscal risk that has not been adequately flagged.

2. Operator compensation must be structured carefully.

Public transport operators will be compensated for lost revenue. The mechanism matters. If

compensation is based on foregone fare revenue calculated at the concessionary rate per trip, operators have no incentive to manage induced demand or service mix efficiently. If compensation is block-funded based on projected ridership, the risk of forecast error transfers to the operator, which raises different problems.

The proposal does not specify the compensation mechanism. This is not a detail — it determines whether operators are exposed to perverse incentives and who bears the downside risk of demand forecasting error. MOT and LTA need to resolve this before any announcement. It cannot be left to implementation.

3. The peak-hour boundary will be gamed at the margins.

The proposal defines off-peak as weekdays 10am–4pm and after 8pm. The 10am boundary is the one that concerns us. Seniors who want to travel free have an incentive to delay a 9:30am trip to 10:00am. The aggregate effect of many seniors doing this creates a demand spike at exactly the boundary — precisely the crowding the proposal is designed to avoid generating.

This is not hypothetical. It is the standard behavioural response to a price cliff at a time boundary, and we have seen versions of it in existing peak and off-peak fare structures. The 8pm boundary is less concerning because there is less latent demand in that direction.

MOT recommends LTA model the boundary effect and consider whether the 10am threshold should be moved to 10:30am, with a corresponding communications strategy that is honest about why.

4. Weekend free travel deserves separate analysis.

Weekday off-peak and weekend travel are not the same operationally. Weekend services — particularly on bus routes serving residential areas and leisure destinations — already carry significant loads. The proposal treats weekends as categorically off-peak. That is not accurate for all routes or all times.

Saturday morning on the Circle Line is not comparable to Tuesday at 11am. Free weekend travel will generate more trips than free Tuesday midday travel, and those trips will fall on a network that is not running at low utilisation. LTA should model weekend demand uplift by route and time band before this is confirmed. If specific routes or times are already under pressure, the scheme should be calibrated accordingly — or those windows should remain concessionary rather than free.

5. Universality versus targeting — MOT's position.

MSF has made the welfare targeting argument. MOT's concern is different but reaches the same conclusion.

A universal benefit at $95–140 million annually is a permanent structural claim on the transport budget. That budget also funds network reliability, accessibility upgrades, active mobility infrastructure, and ongoing rail expansion. These are not optional expenditures. They are the foundation on which everything else — including this scheme's usefulness to seniors — depends.

If the free travel scheme grows in cost and competes for the same budget envelope as station accessibility upgrades or bus service improvements in underserved areas, the equity calculus inverts. The seniors who most need accessible stations and reliable bus services in non-central areas lose out

to fund free fares for seniors who live near well-served interchanges and do not need the subsidy.

MOT therefore supports means-limiting this scheme, not primarily on fiscal grounds — though those matter — but because a universal scheme poorly targeted on welfare grounds also crowds out infrastructure investment that serves a broader equity purpose. These are connected.

MSF's proposed threshold — Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, Merdeka Generation — is workable. MOT would add one operational note: the back-end systems to flag eligibility through the Concession Card already partially exist for Pioneer and Merdeka Generation discounts. This is not a significant implementation obstacle.

6. The age threshold shift from 60 to 65 creates a real gap.

MSF has flagged this. MOT concurs and adds a specific operational concern. Seniors between 60 and 64 on the current Concession Card who are aware of this proposal will notice that they have been excluded. If this generates political pressure to extend eligibility back to 60, the cost model changes substantially — and the off-peak capacity utilisation rationale weakens, because the 60–64 cohort includes more working adults whose trips are more likely to concentrate at peak boundaries.

The proposal needs to either justify the 65 threshold explicitly, or be prepared for pressure to lower it and have a costed response ready. At present, it has neither.

7. The evaluation framework must include transport metrics, not just welfare metrics.

MOT agrees with MSF that ridership data alone is insufficient to evaluate welfare outcomes. We also note the reverse: welfare outcome data alone is insufficient to evaluate whether this is good transport policy.

MOT needs to track: induced demand volumes and their distribution across time and route, crowding indices at peak boundaries, impact on bus dwell times and schedule adherence as senior boardings increase at busy stops, and operator cost structures under increased loads. These are not administrative details. If the scheme generates service quality degradation for other passengers — including lower-income commuters who cannot afford alternatives — that is a welfare failure of a different kind. It needs to be measured.

The evaluation framework should be jointly owned by MOT, LTA, and MSF from the outset. Ridership data is MOT and LTA's input. Welfare outcomes are MSF's input. Neither is sufficient alone.

Specific Answers to the Open Questions

Should free travel be universal or limited to lower-income seniors?

Limited. MOT supports the MSF position: Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, and Merdeka Generation as the threshold, delivered automatically through the existing card. The back-end systems can support this without a new application requirement. Universal free travel at this cost level is not fiscally defensible within the transport budget, and it crowds out investment that serves broader equity goals.

Will free travel shift trips into peak-hour edges?

Yes, at the 10am boundary. This is a design flaw, not a marginal risk. It needs to be addressed before

implementation, either by adjusting the threshold or by modelling the impact and accepting it with eyes open. MOT cannot accept a scheme where the boundary effect is unmodelled.

Is an open-ended commitment prudent?

No. MOT agrees with MSF on the five-year term and statutory evaluation requirement. We add: the evaluation must include a transport impact assessment, not just a welfare assessment, and it must be conducted independently of LTA, which has an institutional interest in reporting positive outcomes.

Additional Issue Not Raised in the Proposal

The proposal is silent on integration with other active ageing transport measures — the existing Community Silver Trust, the Taxi Subsidy

MOF *Ministry of Finance*

MINISTRY OF FINANCE

Inter-Agency Consultation Response

Free Off-Peak Public Transport for Seniors — Draft Proposal

For Discussion

Overall Position

MOF does not oppose the welfare objective. We oppose the fiscal design. The proposal as drafted creates a permanent, open-ended spending commitment of material size, based on an unvalidated cost model, funded through a mechanism that provides no structural check on growth. That is not a minor implementation issue. It is the central problem with the proposal.

MSF and MOT have made the targeting and operational arguments well. MOF will not repeat them. We will address what they have not: the fiscal architecture, the cost model, the compensation mechanism, and the long-term liability this proposal creates.

The Cost Estimate Is Not Reliable

The proposal states $95 million annually, rising to $140 million by 2032. These numbers are presented as estimates. They should be treated as lower bounds.

Three reasons.

First, the estimate is based on current senior ridership patterns applied to a zero-price scenario. Zero-price schemes consistently generate demand above modelled levels. The demand elasticity assumptions underlying this estimate have not been published. Until they are, the $95 million figure cannot be taken seriously as a planning number. MOT has made this point. MOF endorses it and adds: this is not a technical dispute about elasticity parameters. It is a question of whether the

proposal has been honestly costed. At present, it has not.

Second, the eligible population grows. Seniors aged 65 and above will increase as the resident population ages. The $140 million figure for 2032 reflects demographic growth alone. It does not reflect induced demand. The actual 2032 cost could be materially higher. The proposal does not model this.

Third, the cost is framed as foregone fare revenue. That framing understates the true fiscal exposure. If the scheme generates additional trips — which is its stated purpose — operators incur additional operating costs: fuel, labour, maintenance, wear. These costs will need to be addressed in operator compensation. The proposal does not acknowledge them. Depending on how the compensation mechanism is structured, these costs fall either on the Consolidated Fund or on operators, who will raise them in the next licence review. Either way, the public bears them. The proposal should say so.

MOF requires LTA to publish a full demand model with stated elasticity assumptions, a sensitivity analysis at plus-20 and plus-40 percent of projected demand, and a cost estimate that includes induced operating costs, before this proposal proceeds further.

The Funding Mechanism Is Inadequate

The proposal states that costs will be absorbed within the existing transport budget envelope for the first three years, then reviewed. This is not a funding mechanism. It is a deferral.

Absorbing $95 million within the existing envelope means displacing other transport expenditure. MOT has identified what that displaces: station accessibility, network reliability, bus services in underserved areas. Those are not discretionary items. They cannot simply be deferred without affecting service quality and the equity outcomes the proposal claims to advance.

If the transport budget cannot absorb this commitment without displacement, then the cost must be explicitly funded through the budget process — a new line, defended on its merits, visible to Parliament. The proposal avoids this by framing absorption as a first step and review as a mechanism. That framing obscures the real choice: either existing transport investment is cut, or additional funds are allocated. There is no third option. The proposal should state which.

After three years, the review mechanism is undefined. There is no stated criterion for what the review assesses, who conducts it, what a negative outcome looks like, or what happens if costs have exceeded projections. A review with no defined criteria and no exit mechanism is not a fiscal control. It is a formality.

This Proposal Creates Structural Spending

Free public transport for seniors, once introduced, is politically very difficult to withdraw. The proposal does not acknowledge this. It should.

This is not a one-off grant or a time-limited scheme. It is a permanent entitlement delivered through an existing card to a growing eligible population. Once seniors have adjusted their behaviour — their social patterns, their service access, their family visit routines — on the assumption of free travel, any withdrawal or means-testing after the fact will be experienced as a cut, regardless of whether the

fiscal case for it is sound.

Singapore's fiscal model depends on the ability to make clear-eyed decisions about long-term spending commitments before they are made, not after. This proposal proposes to make a commitment of that kind without honestly accounting for its permanence. That is the wrong sequence.

MOF's position: if this scheme proceeds, it must be legislated as a time-limited scheme with a fixed sunset date, not a permanent entitlement subject to periodic review. Renewal must require an affirmative decision — not a decision to not act. This inverts the default. That inversion matters.

Universality Compounds the Fiscal Problem

MSF and MOT have both argued for means-limiting the scheme on welfare and operational grounds. MOF supports that position on fiscal grounds, and adds the following.

A universal benefit at this cost level applied to a growing population has compounding fiscal exposure. If the eligible population grows by 30 percent between now and 2035 — a reasonable projection — and if induced demand adds a further 20 percent to trip volumes, the annual cost could reach $200 million or above before 2035. That is before any adjustment to the compensation mechanism for operating costs.

A means-limited scheme — Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, Merdeka Generation as MSF proposes — would cover a substantially smaller eligible population. MOF requires a costed comparison before this proceeds: the universal model against the means-limited model, with the same demand assumptions applied to both. That comparison does not exist in the current proposal. It should have been the starting point.

There is also a revenue integrity point. A universal free travel benefit for seniors aged 65 and above sets a precedent for other universal age-based benefits. Once the principle is established that age alone is a sufficient basis for a free public service, the argument for extension — to other services, other age groups, other modalities — becomes structurally harder to resist. MOF is alert to this. Other ministries should be too.

Operator Compensation Must Be Resolved Before Announcement

MOT has raised this. MOF reinforces it from a public expenditure perspective.

The proposal commits to compensating operators from the Consolidated Fund. The mechanism is unspecified. This matters for several reasons.

If compensation is trip-based at the concessionary rate, operators have no incentive to manage induced demand efficiently. They also have an incentive to over-report senior trips.

If compensation is block-funded on projected ridership, the risk of demand forecast error transfers to the government — which means to the Consolidated Fund — when actual ridership exceeds projection.

Either structure requires robust audit and verification. The proposal says nothing about how

operator claims will be verified or audited. For a scheme disbursing $95 million annually from the Consolidated Fund, that is not acceptable. MOF will require an audit framework as a condition of any Consolidated Fund appropriation.

There is also a procurement governance question. If this compensation is paid to a small number of operators under existing licence arrangements, the basis for the compensation rate needs to be independently validated, not self-reported by operators. LTA should not be both the scheme administrator and the sole verifier of operator claims.

On the Open Questions

Should free travel be universal or limited to lower-income seniors?

Limited. This is not a close question fiscally. The means-limited model delivers the stated welfare objectives at a fraction of the cost. Universal free travel delivers a windfall to seniors who do not need it, at a cost that grows structurally with the population. MOF supports Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, and Merdeka Generation as the threshold, with automatic eligibility through the existing card. If LTA's back-end systems can already flag Pioneer and Merdeka Generation status — as MOT indicates — this is implementable without significant additional cost.

Will free travel shift trips into peak-hour edges?

MOT has addressed this operationally. MOF adds: if the 10am boundary generates a crowding spike, the policy response — adjusting service frequency, adding capacity — has a cost. That cost is not in this proposal. The proposal cannot claim to use spare capacity and simultaneously require additional capacity investment to manage boundary effects. Those are contradictory. The boundary effect needs to be modelled, and if it generates additional service cost, that cost belongs in the fiscal estimate.

Is an open-ended commitment prudent?

No. Five-year sunset, affirmative renewal requirement, evaluation criteria defined in advance and published, independent evaluation — not conducted by LTA. MOF will not support an open-ended commitment for a scheme of this cost on the basis of a review mechanism that is undefined and non-

ORCHESTRATOR SYNTHESIS

ORCHESTRATOR *Policy Analyst · Synthesis*

INTER-AGENCY CONSULTATION: ANALYTICAL SYNTHESIS

Free Off-Peak Public Transport for Seniors

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1. FAULT LINES

A. Universality vs. Targeting — Values Disagreement Dressed as Fiscal Disagreement

All three agencies oppose universal free travel. But they oppose it for different reasons, and those differences matter.

MSF opposes universality because it is a blunt instrument for a targeted welfare problem. The concern is about effective reach — whether the policy actually helps the people it claims to help.

MOT opposes universality because the budget is finite and universal free travel crowds out infrastructure investment that serves broader equity goals. The concern is about opportunity cost within a fixed envelope.

MOF opposes universality because it creates structural, compounding fiscal exposure and sets a precedent for other age-based entitlements. The concern is about long-term public finance discipline.

These are genuinely different positions. MSF's argument holds even if costs were low. MOF's argument holds even if the welfare targeting were perfect. Conflating them obscures what is actually being decided: whether this is a welfare instrument, a transport instrument, or both — and who owns it.

This is not a resolvable technical dispute. It is a policy design choice about what government is doing and for whom. No amount of modelling settles it.

B. Fiscal Risk — Evidence Disagreement

The proposal presents $95 million as an estimate. MOF and MOT treat it as an underestimate. The proposal's authors appear to treat it as a planning figure.

The disagreement is about: demand elasticity assumptions, induced operating costs, and the gap between foregone fare revenue and true fiscal exposure. MOF identifies a specific structural problem — the estimate excludes induced operating costs entirely. That is not a modelling quibble. It is a material omission.

No agency has seen the demand model. Until LTA publishes it, this disagreement cannot be resolved. The consultation is proceeding without the primary evidence it needs.

C. The Age Threshold — Jurisdiction Dressed as Evidence

The shift from 60 to 65 is presented in the proposal as an unstated assumption. MSF questions it on welfare grounds. MOT questions it on political and operational grounds. Neither challenges it head-on.

No agency has stated plainly what is likely true: the 65 threshold was chosen to reduce the eligible population and contain costs, not because evidence shows that isolation risk spikes at 65. If that is the case, it should be said. The proposal has imported a fiscal decision and presented it as a design choice.

This is a jurisdiction question masquerading as a welfare question. MOF set the cost envelope. LTA

drew the age line. Nobody has said so.

D. Sunset vs. Permanent Entitlement — Genuine Values Disagreement

MSF wants a five-year statutory sunset with welfare outcome metrics. MOT wants a five-year sunset with independent transport evaluation. MOF wants a statutory sunset with an affirmative renewal requirement — inverting the political default.

The proposal has a "review after three years." That is not the same thing.

The substantive disagreement here is not about duration. It is about what happens when the scheme is reviewed. MSF and MOT assume the default is renewal unless evidence argues otherwise. MOF insists the default must be expiry unless there is an affirmative case for renewal. MOF is right that this distinction matters enormously in practice — politically, a running scheme is almost impossible to cancel regardless of evidence.

This is a real disagreement about fiscal governance, not a drafting issue. The proposal avoids it entirely.

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2. UNEXPECTED CONSENSUS

A. Automatic Eligibility — Universal Agreement, No Dissent

All three agencies support the automatic eligibility mechanism without reservation. MSF argues it from uptake evidence. MOT accepts it as operationally sound. MOF does not challenge it.

This is notable because it is the one design feature that could have generated a targeting vs. simplicity argument. It did not. Even MOF — the most skeptical agency — does not propose replacing automatic eligibility with an application process.

This is settled. Do not reopen it. Build on it.

The immediate corollary: means-limiting the scheme through Silver Support, Pioneer Generation, and Merdeka Generation status can be implemented automatically through the existing card. MOT confirms the back-end systems partially exist. This removes the main practical objection to a targeted approach.

B. Means-Limiting — Convergent Conclusion from Different Starting Points

MSF, MOT, and MOF all conclude that universal free travel is wrong and that the Silver Support / Pioneer / Merdeka threshold is workable. They arrive there via different arguments — welfare precision, budget opportunity cost, fiscal compounding — but they land in the same place.

This is stronger than it looks. When three agencies with different mandates and different framings converge on the same design answer, that answer is probably right.

There is no serious inter-agency case for universality. The proposal's default position has no defenders in this consultation.

C. Independent Evaluation — Consensus Against LTA Self-Assessment

MOT says the evaluation must be independent of LTA, which has an institutional interest in positive outcomes. MOF says the same. MSF implies it by insisting on welfare metrics that LTA would not naturally collect or prioritise.

No agency trusts LTA to evaluate its own scheme. That is significant given that LTA is both the scheme administrator and the operator compensation authority. The conflict of interest is structural, not personal.

This needs to be resolved in the governance design before implementation, not flagged as a concern after.

D. Off-Peak Targeting — Operational Logic Accepted

MSF accepts the off-peak window as aligned with the behaviour of isolated seniors. MOT accepts it as a sound use of spare capacity. MOF does not challenge it.

The 10am boundary generates concern — but the concept of off-peak targeting itself is not contested.

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3. UNANSWERED QUESTIONS

A. Where Is the Demand Model?

The $95 million figure is the load-bearing number in this proposal. It determines fiscal feasibility, budget absorption, operator compensation levels, and the review trigger. No agency has seen the assumptions behind it. The proposal has not published them.

This is not an oversight. It is the central missing piece. Every fiscal and operational concern raised by MOT and MOF is downstream of this gap.

The proposal cannot proceed to the next stage without a published demand model, sensitivity analysis, and cost estimate that includes induced operating costs.

B. What Happens After the Review?

The three-year review has no defined criteria, no stated outcome, no exit mechanism, and no stated owner. MOF identifies this precisely. A review with no decision rule is not a control — it is an administrative event.

The proposal must answer: what would cause the scheme not to be renewed? Who decides? What is the threshold?

Without answers, the "review" is cosmetic and the commitment is effectively permanent from day one.

C. What Does "Within the Transport Budget Envelope" Actually Mean?

This phrase appears once and is never explained. MOT and MOF both identify that absorbing $95

million within the existing envelope requires displacing something else. Neither knows what. The proposal does not say.

This is not a rounding error. It is a decision that has been hidden inside a technical phrase. Name what gets cut, or acknowledge that additional funding is required.

D. How Will Operator Compensation Be Structured and Audited?

MOT raises the perverse incentives. MOF raises the audit gap. Neither has received an answer.

Specifically unanswered: What is the basis for the compensation rate? Who verifies operator claims? Who audits them? What prevents over-reporting? Can LTA independently audit operators it also licenses and commercially regulates?

For a scheme paying $95 million annually from the Consolidated Fund, these are not administrative details.

E. What Is the Counterfactual for the Most Isolated Seniors?

MSF raises this and receives no response from the other agencies. For seniors with physical frailty, cognitive decline, fear of falling, or no accompanying support — the cost of transport is not the binding constraint. Free fares do not help them.

The proposal does not quantify what proportion of the target population faces non-cost barriers. It does not propose any complementary measure. It assumes the link between free travel and reduced isolation without establishing it.

If the scheme succeeds on its own terms but fails to reach the most isolated, it will be declared a success while missing its objective. This needs to be acknowledged explicitly, not buried.

F. What Happens to Service Capacity at Community Destinations?

MSF flags that increased senior mobility will increase footfall at senior activity centres, family service centres, and community mental health touchpoints. MSF's sector is not operating with spare capacity. This is a coordination gap between MSF, MOH, and PA.

The proposal is silent on this. If the scheme works as intended, it will create demand pressures elsewhere that are not funded and not planned for. That is a design failure, not an implementation risk.

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4. MISSING ACTORS

A. Ministry of Finance's Budget Process — Structurally Absent

MOF has submitted concerns. But the budget process itself — how this scheme gets funded, what line it appears on, what Parliamentary scrutiny it receives — is absent from the consultation. The proposal routes money through operator compensation from the Consolidated Fund in a way that may avoid a transparent budget line. If $95 million annually is not a visible appropriation, Parliament

cannot scrutinise it. That is a governance problem, not a transport problem.

B. Public Transport Operators

The operators receive compensation under this scheme. They also bear the operational consequences — increased loads, potential service degradation, audit obligations. They have not submitted. Their cost structure, their views on the compensation mechanism, and their operational capacity to absorb demand growth are entirely absent.

For a scheme that functionally restructures their revenue and liability exposure, this is a significant omission.

C. Commuters Aged 20–60

The proposal's off-peak capacity argument depends on the assumption that free senior travel does not degrade service quality for other passengers. MOT raises the boundary effect at 10am. Neither MOT nor the proposal addresses the broader question: if weekend services on busy routes become more crowded, lower-income commuters — who cannot afford alternatives — bear the cost.

These commuters are not in the room. They have no mechanism to raise this concern. It should be assessed on their behalf.

D. Seniors Aged 60–64

The proposal shifts the eligibility threshold from 60 to 65. Seniors currently on the Concession Card in the 60–64 cohort will notice this. Some may be at elevated isolation risk, may be on low incomes, and will see no benefit. They have not been consulted. Their reaction — and the political consequences — has not been assessed.

MSF and MOT both flag this. It remains unanswered.

E. Ministry of Health

The proposal's primary welfare claim — that transport cost drives social isolation, and social isolation is a health and welfare risk — is centrally a public health claim. MOH is absent. Nobody has asked MOH whether the evidence linking transport cost to isolation risk is strong enough to support a $95 million annual commitment. Nobody has asked MOH whether free transport competes with or complements other social prescribing or active ageing investments. Nobody has asked MOH about the capacity of community mental health services to absorb increased demand.

MSF flags the MOH coordination gap. But the absence is deeper than coordination. MOH should be a principal in this consultation, not a downstream recipient of its consequences.

F. People's Association and Social Service Offices

PA runs senior activity centres and community clubs — the destinations this scheme is designed to make accessible. Social Service Offices manage Silver Support eligibility — the administrative

mechanism on which a means-limited scheme depends. Neither has submitted. If Silver Support data is used to gate eligibility, SSO's data quality and update frequency become critical. Nobody has asked them whether that data is current enough to use in real-time fare gating.

OVERALL ASSESSMENT

The proposal has a sound instinct and a weak architecture.

The instinct — that transport cost is a real barrier for some isolated seniors, that off-peak capacity is underused, and that automatic eligibility is the right delivery mechanism — is defensible and has inter-agency support.

The architecture is not ready. The cost model is unpublished and likely underestimated. The funding mechanism obscures real choices. The review process is cosmetic. The target population is too broad. The most important missing question — whether free travel actually reduces isolation — is assumed rather than tested. And the scheme's success depends on actors who are not in the consultation.

Three decisions need to be made before this proceeds:

One. Means-limited or universal. The consultation has answered this: means-limited. Implement that decision.

Two. What is the real cost. Publish the demand model. Run it at plus-20 and plus-40 percent. Include induced operating costs. Produce a costed comparison of universal versus means-limited. This should have existed before the consultation, not after.

Three. Sunset or permanent entitlement. The consultation has answered this too: statutory sunset, affirmative renewal, defined criteria, independent evaluation. Write that into the legislation, not the explanatory notes.

Until those three decisions are resolved and documented, this proposal is not ready for announcement.